Where is register?
Deriving grammatical free variation within one single grammar[*]

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Abstract: This study offers an analysis of the modal and register dimensions of the analytical/synthetic alternation in the Spanish future/conditional to the effect of showing that grammatical free variation in the register dimension can be modeled within one single grammar as part of the core linguistic knowledge any speaker is competent with. This is particularly reasonable in a multidimensional semantic framework according to which register pertains to the semantic agenda in its own right. In the theory favored in this paper, different meaning dimensions have different derivational paths, with truth-conditional meaning standardly derived in the syntax-LF interface, and register, in the way from syntax to PF. The analysis is extended to account for the "free" choice of the definite article in referential uses of proper names in certain Spanish varieties. An important corollary of the analysis is that if structures and meanings bifurcate in the way suggested, then a new heuristic to detect true grammatical variation can be deduced.
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1. Introduction
The main aim of this study is to offer a perhaps novel way to think of patterns of *grammatical free variation* within a version of multidimensional semantics (Kaplan 1999, Potts 2005, McCready 2010, Gutzmann 2015, and, in particular, Saab 2021a). Specifically, I would like to develop some preliminary arguments in favor of a theory that accounts for *variation in use* without reference to competition among grammars (Kroch 1989, 1994, 2001 and Embick 2007 for a recent lucid presentation).[1] Concretely, I propose that morphological rules can manipulate the same syntactic output in various restricted ways. When this happens, we obtain a difference in use-conditions for truth-conditionally equivalent pairs, a well-known state of affairs in the languages of the world. Here, I will focus on a particular case study involving the synthetic/analytic distinction in the Spanish future/conditional. Consider the following minimal pair in Rioplatense Spanish:

(1) [*context*: the speaker is indicating a future event]
 a. Estudiaré. [synthetic, specific formal situations]
 study.FUT.1SG
 'I will study.'
 b. Voy a estudiar. [analytic, informal/everyday use]

[*] This paper presents partial results obtained from research I carried out between 2024 and 2025 within *The Collaborative Research Center 1412 "Register: Language Users' Knowledge of Situational-Functional Variation" (CRC 1412)*. See Lüdeling *et al* (2022) for an excellent state of the art in the theory of register and the research questions and aims that frame the entire project.
[1] Adger (2006) also challenges the *competing grammar* view, but from a different perspective. He argues that there can be after all variation in exponence for functional items. I will not take any specific stance regarding this type of variation, and just assume that Kroch (1989, 1994) is in principle right regarding the rarity of functional doublets. As I said, according to him, the odd cases follow when there is competition between two different grammatical systems. I have nothing to say with respect to the multilingual solution for functional doublets. What I do challenge is also Kroch's idea that there must not be synthetic/analytical doublets of the type to be discussed here either.

go.PRES.1SG to study.INF
'I am going to study.'

For a Rioplatense speaker, the contrast between (1a) and (1b) clearly reduces to a register difference, with the synthetic form restricted to particular formal situations, canonically, academic texts, but not only. In turn, (1b) is the everyday way to express the future in this dialect. Regarding these patterns, there is then the important question whether the contrast in (1) can be derived within one single grammar or if, on the contrary, it reflects a situation in which two grammatical systems are in competition. On this second view, the alternation between (1a) and (1b) can be thought of as special case of code-switching situation. I will not follow this line of reasoning here. Instead, I will provide plausible analyses for each case in (1) within the same grammatical system. In other words, it is part of the competence of the Rioplatense Spanish speaker "knowing" that (i) her grammar generates the two outputs in (1), and (ii) this type of morphological derivations impacts in use-conditions, but not in truth-conditions.

Now, the Rioplatense speaker also knows that a form of the synthetic future can also "block" the analytic strategy. Put another way, if what the speaker wants to convey is epistemic modality, then only the synthetic form is felicitous:

(2) A. Dónde está Ana?
where is Ana
'Where is Ana?'
B. No sé. {Estará, #va a estar} en su casa.
not know.1SG be.FUT.3SG, goes to be.INF in her home
'I don't know. She might be at home.'

The contrast in (2) shows that whenever differences in truth-conditions or, more precisely, in LF structures, can be detected, there are plausible reasons to suspect different syntactic derivations in which some type of "blocking" effect is observed.

A similar pattern is attested with the synthetic/analytic alternation of the conditional. The contrasts in (3) are only about register, with the synthetic form in (3a) restricted to formal, mostly written texts, and the analytic form in (3b) restricted to neutral situations for expressing future in the past.

(3) [*context*: the speaker is indicating a future event in the past]
a. Estudiaría durante varios días.
study.COND.1SG during several days
'I would study for several days.'
b. Iba a estudiar varios días.
go.PAST.1SG to study.INF several days
'I was going to study for several days.'

The modal scenario is more complex than in the future. On the one hand, as before, epistemic modality in the past can be expressed but only with the synthetic conditional, not the analytic one:

(4) A. Dónde estaba Ana?
where was Ana

	'Where was Ana?'							
B.	No sé.	{Estaría,	#iba	a	estar}	en	su	casa.
	not know.1SG	be.COND.3SG,	was	to	be.INF	in	her	home
	'I don't know. She was probably at home.'							

On the other, the conditional also has a perhaps evidential use:

(5)	Escuché	que	aumentarían	los	salarios
	hear.PAST.1SG	that	raise.COND.3PL	the	salaries
	el	próximo	mes.		
	the	next	month		
	'I heard they would raise wages next month.'				

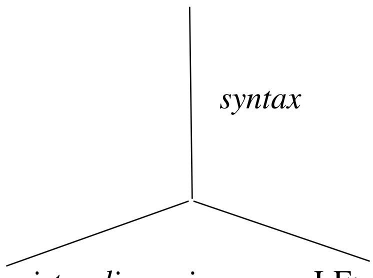
In this paper, I will only be concerned with the future in its register and modal dimensions and assume that the analyses to be provided can plausibly be extended to the conditional with proper adaptations.

What I have just said with respect to the register/modal dimensions has important implications with respect to the proper morphosyntactic derivation of the synthetic/analytic alternation in the Spanish future/conditional. One of such implications is that, on the view to be defended, the two synthetic futures in Rioplatense Spanish just introduced correspond to two different syntactic derivations. In other words, the pair *estudiaré*.FORMAL/ *estudiaré*.MODAL is accounted for as a standard case of structural ambiguity. There are, then, two patterns in need of an explanation. In effect, we observed that the synthetic form of the future blocks the analytic future in the modal dimension, whereas there is no blocking in any direction in the register dimension. To account for this peculiar situation, I defend the idea that blocking directly follows from standard assumptions about the syntax-LF derivation. The register dimension, in turn, is entirely derived in the path from syntax to PF.

(6) The analytic/synthetic alternation in two dimensions:
a. Modal dimension (Syntax→LF): #*voy a estudiar*.FUTURE / *estudiaré*.MODAL
b. Register dimension (Syntax→PF): *voy a estudiar*.NEUTRAL / *estudiaré*.FORMAL

The scheme in (7) illustrates the architectural thesis I have in mind:

(7)



PF: *register dimension* LF: *modal dimension*

The pair in (1), then, forms a natural class with a myriad of other phenomena connected to what Saab (2021a) calls *stylistic semantics*, i.e., the theory that correlates expressivity/register to the mechanics of non-representational grammar. In the following section, I briefly introduce the basic assumptions of Distributed Morphology, the general theory of the syntax/PF interface I adopt, and the ingredients of the theory of non-representational grammar and stylistic semantics I have sketched in Saab (2021a). In section 3, I address the register and modal dimensions of the Spanish future. Following Kornfeld (2004), I argue that in the register dimension, the narrow syntax derivation of the analytical and synthetic futures is identical and is differentiated within PF via free variation of two post-syntactic rules: (i) Lowering (synthetic), and (ii) auxiliary-insertion (analytical). I contend that two truth-conditionally identical structures with different PF-derivations have different non-representational meanings read by the context system (Reinhart 2006), register in this case. In turn, under the modal meaning, a different syntactic derivation blocks the analytical form, delivering the synthetic form to PF and the modal structure for interpretation at LF. Put differently, the synthetic future is structurally ambiguous, in the usual sense. In section 4, I offer some further theoretical comments and briefly discuss the attested variation in the use of definite articles in referential uses of proper names in some Spanish varieties. This pattern responds positively to the entire set of properties that allow us to detect (i) grammatical free variation at PF, and (ii) non-representational meaning, register and interpersonal proximity, in this case. Some final remarks are given in the concluding section.

2. A research program for non-representational grammar

In this section, I introduce, first, some theoretical background assumptions of Distributed Morphology (Halle and Marantz 1993, Embick 2000, Embick and Noyer 2001, Saab 2008, Arregi and Nevins 2012, and Harley 2014, among many others). These assumptions underline the project of non-representational grammar offered in Saab (2021a), which briefly described in section 2.2.

2.1. The syntax-PF interface

With most versions of Distributed Morphology, I assume that syntax generates abstract structures out of two basic primitive objects: abstract morphemes and roots. Abstract morphemes correspond to abstract syntactic-semantic features taken from a universal inventory, such as [past], [plural], [author of the speech act], and so on, whereas roots are mere indexes. Combinations of abstract morphemes and roots are sent to the Phonetic Form (PF) and Logical Form (LF) interfaces where they are independently interpreted for production and thought, respectively. At the PF interface, syntactic terminal nodes are given phonological content through a set of vocabulary insertion rules. For roots, the procedure is entirely deterministic: a numeric index is simply replaced with a phonetic form stored at PF:

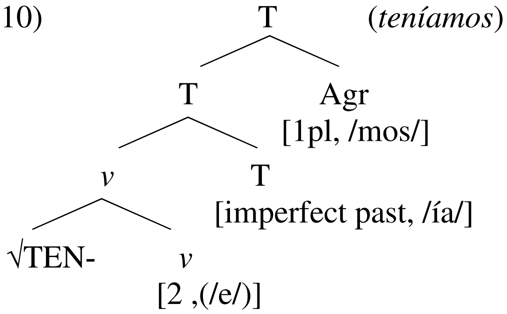
(8) a. √132 ↔ /sól/ root for 'sun'
b. √56 ↔ /més-/ root for 'table'
c. √98 ↔ /kánt-/ root for the verb 'to sing'

The addition of phonological content for abstract morphemes requires instead competition among an ordered list of possible candidates for insertion. For instance, Spanish has two phonological exponents for the *pretérito imperfecto*, /-ba/ and /ía/. Here, allomorphy follows from a sort of matching between the morphosyntactic environment and the information encoded in the vocabulary items themselves. In this case, the /ía/ exponent encodes its condition for insertion; concretely, /ía/ is inserted when the thematic vowel corresponds to the 2 or 3 conjugations (i.e., *temer/partir*) and the /ba/ exponent is the elsewhere case, i.e., it applies in the rest of the environments.

(9) [imperfect past] ↔ /ía/ /$VT_{2/3}$___
[imperfect past] ↔ /ba/, elsewhere

Thus, a simplified derivation for a second conjugation verb like *teníamos* ‘we had’ would have a least the following ingredients:

(10)



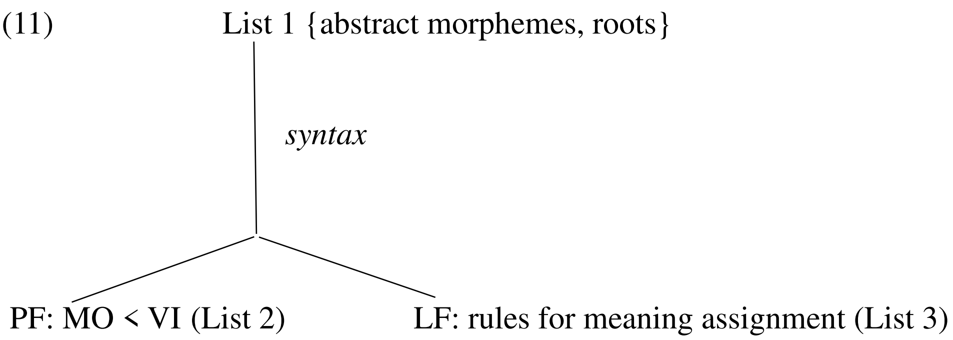
Now, the morphological component is not only about vocabulary insertion, but also about *morphological manipulations*; otherwise, we would expect a perfect match between syntax and PF, not the usual case (Embick and Noyer 2001). In this respect, an important claim in Distributed Morphology is that syntax alone is not enough to account for various sorts of affixations, clitic orderings and deletions. For instance, some affixations require PF-movements of different kinds. This confronts with the view according to which narrow syntax performs the entire set of displacement operations. In Embick and Noyer’s own words, the two views can be stated as follows:

“*Syntax only:* Syntax performs operations that are explicitly executed so as to resolve a morphophonological problem. Patterns of apparent postsyntactic movement are reducible to the effects of these ‘‘special’’ syntactic processes.
PF movement: Syntax generates and moves terminals according to its own principles and is oblivious to morphophonological concerns. PF takes the output of syntax and resolves morphophonological dependencies according to its own principles.”

[Embick and Noyer 2001: 556-557]

In this paper, I adopt the second theory of word formation. On this view, as advanced, in the path from syntax to PF, abstract morphemes and roots are combined according to the principles of syntax. Then, the output of syntax can be manipulated by the PF interface via the application of different sorts of morphological operations (MO) consisting of insertions, displacements or deletions restricted by morphological principles. To that output, the rules of Vocabulary Insertion (VI) give phonological content to the terminal nodes. This requires consulting a list of VIs encoding information for insertion (List 2). At the other interface, the output of syntax is also interpreted but now according to LF rules. Among those rules, there are also operations that assign interpretations on the basis of syntactic information and another list that connects syntax to encyclopedic knowledge (List 3):

(11)



Let me pause with some detail on the information contained in each of the lists in (11), because it will be relevant for subsequent discussion. According to Harley (2014: 228), each of the lists in the diagram in (11) contributes with the following information, which essentially corresponds to what I have said so far:

(12) List 1: *Feature bundles*: syntactic primitives, both interpretable and uninterpretable, functional and contentful
List 2: *Vocabulary Items*: instructions for pronouncing terminal nodes
List 3: *Encyclopedia*: instructions for interpreting terminal nodes

Thus, the full representation for an abstract morpheme like, say, the imperfect past in Spanish (realized as '*-ba/-ía*') requires information taken from the three lists:

(13) List 1: [imperfect past]
List 2: [imperfect past] ↔ /-ía/ / Thematic Vowel$_{2,3}$ __
[imperfect past] ↔ /-ba/
List 3: [imperfect past] ↔ ⟦truth-conditional meaning⟧

Instead, for a root like *pez* 'fish', the relevant information, distributed in each list, can be summarized as follows:

(14) List 1: √13
List 2: √13 ↔ /pés/
List 3: √13 ↔ ⟦λ*x*. Fish(*x*)⟧ / _____*n*

In the following section, I argue that register and at least a subset of related kinds of social or expressive meanings can be entirely derived from information encoded at PF, not LF. This is what I have called *stylistic semantics* in Saab (2021a).

2.2. Non-representational grammar and stylistic semantics

Even with important simplifications, the framework just presented makes some interesting predictions regarding the existence of doublets in the exponence of terminal nodes. Concretely, given the mechanics of Vocabulary Insertion for abstract morphemes and roots, doublets for functional morphemes should be extremely rare or even inexistent (Embick 2007 and references therein). This is because of the nature of competition among functional items, which determines a univocal winner given a list of possible functional candidates. Now, this is not the case for roots, which, at least in general, do not compete for insertion. Interestingly, doublets for roots are productive in the languages of the world. In Rioplatense Spanish, many informal/neutral pairs are attested in the lexical domain. Thus, in the following list, the concept denoted at LF is exactly the same, but the phonetic form varies:

(15) Nouns:
a. cerveza/birra.$_{\text{INFORMAL}}$ 'beer'
b. trabajo/laburo.$_{\text{INFORMAL}}$ 'work'
c. nariz/naso.$_{\text{INFORMAL}}$ 'nose'

(16) Verbs:
a. trabajar/laburar.$_{\text{INFORMAL}}$ 'to work'
b. sudar/chivar.$_{\text{INFORMAL}}$ 'to swear'
c. comer/morfar.$_{\text{INFORMAL}}$ 'to eat'

This is not the normal case with abstract morphemes, in which alternations as (15) and (16) are almost inexistent, e.g., doublets like *trabaj(a)-ba/*ía* are excluded from the system.[2] Despite some of the grey areas that arise at first approximation, the contrast between roots and abstract morphemes is robust. In the framework favored here, this is elegantly accounted for because of the interactions between List 1 and List 2. The system allows for a same LF concept to be represented by different root indexes, which never block each other at the point of Vocabulary Insertion. So, for instance, new indexes can be integrated into a grammatical system as part of the List 1 inventory, a common situation in language contact environments. Indeed, many of the pairs in (15) and (16) are the result of the impact Italian immigration had in the Rioplatense system.

Now, it is worth stressing that, as is well-known at least since Trubetzkoy (1939), free variation normally impacts on the expressive function of language or, as I will say here, on use-conditions (Gutzmann 2015). In Saab (2021a), this was stated as a Principle of Stylistic Meaning:

(17) Principle of stylistic meaning (PSM): Given a pair of abstract nodes X and Y, taken from List 1, if X and Y are not semantically distinguishable at LF (List 3), they are "semantically" distinguished at PF (List 2).

[Saab 2021a: 23]

Evidently, this requires a multidimensional approach to meaningful grammatical objects, according to which PF-meanings do not require LF or post-LF interpretation by the thought system, but interpretation by a cognitive system able to connect linguistic expressions with use-conditions. With Reinhart (2006), I assume that there is indeed a context system independent from the thought system, which she vaguely defines as follows:

"The hardest to define given our present state of knowledge are the context systems that narrow the information transmitted through the derivation (coded in the relevant representation), and select the information that is useful for the context of use."

[Reinhart 2006: 4]

Saab (2021a) makes a more explicit claim regarding the relevant representations, which at least for a subset of the structures generated for the grammatical system are conceived as pure PF representations. Now, given PSM, it must be the case that use-conditions for the relevant set of representations are encoded in List 2. Syntax and LF are simply blind to this type of use-conditional meaning. On this view, the register meaning encoded in the informal *laburar* 'to work' (vs. the neutral *trabajar*) is entirely deduced at PF, specifically, in the concrete vocabulary item. As shown in (18b), following Predelli (2013), I model the register of *laburar* as a bias for use-conditions:[3]

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[2] A well-known exception is the past subjunctive, in which the exponent -*ra*- and -*se*- freely alternate:

(i) amáramos/amásemos 'love.PAST.SUBJ.1PL', 'We had love.'

See Rosemeyer and Schwenter (2019) for an important study on the distribution of the two forms in corpus. As they claim, there is a detectable *persistence* effect in the distribution of the -*se*- form according to which the previous occurrence of a -*se*- form in a given text strongly favors another -*se*- occurrence.

[3] Predelli's theory of bias is probably the more explicit implementation of Kaplan's (1999) original insights on use-conditions for interjections like the English *ouch*. In Kaplan's terms:

"The semantic information in the word "ouch" is —more accurately, is represented by— the set of those contexts at which the word "ouch" is expressively correct (since it contains no descriptive information), namely, the set of

(18) *trabajar vs. laburar:*

a. List 1: [√34 = abstract root for *trabajar*]
List 2: [√34] ↔ /tɾabax-/
List 3: [to work] ↔ ⟦ λx.x works⟧

b. List 1: [abstract root for *labuɾaɾ*]
List 2: [√43] ↔ /labuɾ-/$_{\text{BIAS}}$
List 3: [√43 = to work] ↔ ⟦ λx.x works⟧
{Bias: $c \in CU$(laburar) only if, in c, c_a is a participant in register *informal}*

This approach makes sense of the fact that ellipsis cannot mismatch in register. Consider, for instance, the following instance of nominal ellipsis, in which the neutral *nariz* 'nose' cannot serve as antecedent for the informal *naso*, and vice versa (<…> = ellipsis site):

(19)

a. *el	naso	de	Juan	y	la	<nariz>	de	Andrés
the	nose$_{\text{.M.INFORMAL}}$	of	Juan	and	the	nose.$_{\text{F.NEUTRAL}}$	of	Andrés

'Juan's nose and Andrés'__'

b. * la	nariz	de	Juan	y	el	<naso>	de	Andrés
the	nose$_{\text{.F.NEUTRAL}}$	of	Juan	and	the	nose.$_{\text{M.INFORMAL}}$	of	Andrés

'Juan's nose and Andrés'__ '

Assume that ellipsis requires some sort of lexical-syntactic identity. Then, given that *nariz* and *naso* are represented through different root indexes and that also arbitrary gender mismatches, the two examples in (19) are strongly ungrammatical. To see the point clearly, assume that *nariz* and *naso* have the following rules for PF and LF realizations.

(20)

PF realization:	LF realization:
a. √123 ↔ /narís/	√123 ↔ λx. Nose(x)
b. √12 ↔ /náso/	√12 ↔ λx. Nose(x)

As it is clear, the two words are not distinguished at LF, and, consequently, by PSM, must be distinguished at PF. Let me assume that in List 2 *naso* is then marked for a contextual bias, along the following lines:

(21) PF-*bias: $c \in CU$(naso)* only if, in c, c_a is a participant in register *informal*

The bias is a PF property and then, irrelevant to ellipsis. So, it must be the case that the reason for the ungrammaticality in (19) is because √123 ≠ √12 and M ≠ F in the syntax. This view makes an additional prediction, namely, that ellipsis must nullify whatever biases are encoded in List 2 since elliptical sites cannot indeed contain any List 2 object (i.e., ellipsis is absence of vocabulary insertion). Thus, in cases of TP-ellipsis, like the fragment answer in (22B), the E-

those contexts at which the agent is in pain. That set of contexts represents the semantic information contained in the word "ouch"."

[Kaplan 1999: 16, my underlying]

In Predelli's analysis, we say that *ouch* has the following *bias*, where CU stands for the *context of use* of a given expression, and c_a for the agent of the Kaplanian context:

(i) Bias for *ouch: $c \in CU$(ouch)* only if, in c, c_a is in pain site must contain the same index as the verb in the antecedent. Let us assume that, in fact, the verb *morfar* 'to eat'$_{\text{informal}}$ is the realization of the abstract index √27. Then, given that √27 = √27 in the TP-antecedent and the elided one, the resulting ellipsis is perfectly licit:

(22) A: Qué morfaste?
what ate.2SG.INFORMAL
B: Una pizza <[$_{\text{TP}}$ … <√27> …]>, pero no tolero cuando
a pizza but not tolerate.1SG when
hablás tan informalmente. Yo nunca lo hago.
speak.2SG so informally I never it do
'A pizza. But I don't tolerate it when you speak informally. I never do it.'
[adapted from Saab 2021a: 27]

The verb *morfar* 'to eat' is strongly marked for informal contexts. Again, let us model the PF-bias of the relevant vocabulary item as before, with the corresponding adaptations:

(23) PF-*bias:* $c \in CU(morfar)$ only if, in c, c_a is a participant in register *informal*

The dialogue in (22), then, presents an interesting situation, in which the biased question can serve as a good antecedent for the elided verb in the non-biased fragment answer in (22B).

In sum, the theory of non-representational grammar briefly described here makes some good predictions in intriguing patterns of ellipsis. In this respect, the theory seems to offer a better account than theories that try to explain similar facts by making reference to pure LF or conceptual structures. For instance, Potts *et al* (2009) account for examples like (22B) by proposing that ellipsis only refers to descriptive, not expressive content. Yet, this approach cannot account for the nominal ellipsis case in (19). In the same vein, Sauerland and Alexiadou (2020) discuss a similar fact of bias mitigation under ellipsis in German. I reproduce their crucial example below:

(24) A: Ich habe Ihren Köter im Park gesehen.
I have your-HON fleabagin park seen
'I saw your fleabag in the park.'
B: In welchem?
in which?
'In which park (did you see my dog)?'
[Sauerland and Alexiadou 2020: 8]

Sauerland and Alexiadou propose that concepts are structured in an Algebra of Thought which essentially derives complex conceptual representations out of conceptual primitives. The output this system delivers is realized through *language*. On this view, thought has primacy over language, which can be reduced to a mechanism of compression of conceptual representations. One consequence of this Meaning First Approach (MF, as they call it) is that it requires universal late insertion of roots (Marantz 1995, among others), but in addition, the approach models them as mere concepts in the Algebra of Thought. The same abstract concept can be realized by different roots by the compressor (i.e., language), which, in turn, can formally encode what they call *socio-emotive* properties. For instance, for the concept of *dog*, German has at least the two following root exponents, one of which is socio-affectively marked:

(25) a. dog →*"Köter"* (⇑ disgust, ⇓ formal)

b. dog →*“Hund”*

[Sauerland and Alexiadou 2020: 8]

If, as they argue, ellipsis only requires identity of conceptual representations, the absence of the pejorative flavor in (24B) is straightforwardly predicted in the reply. At least for this type of example, their analysis seems to be extensionally equivalent to the one offered in Saab (2021a) briefly presented here (see Sauerland and Alexiadou 2020, footnote 36 for a similar conclusion). This is because for Sauerland and Alexiadou, the socio-affective dimension is also a property of a form. However, both analyses differ in one crucial respect, namely, the type of abstract object ellipsis targets. On my view, ellipsis refers to root indexes and abstracts morphemes, whereas for Sauerland and Alexiadou, ellipsis refers to conceptual representations. Both approaches can explain the relevant facts, because both assume universal late insertion of roots and associate socio-emotive properties with the exponents, not with the concepts or with the abstract morphemes/root indexes. However, the MF view cannot deal well with the NP-ellipsis facts in (19) in which conceptual identity is observed, but the output is strongly ungrammatical. As we have seen, in the T-model adopted here, both exponents and concepts for roots come after realization at the interfaces. See again the proposed rules for PF and LF interpretation in (20), repeated below:

(26)	<u>PF realization</u>:	<u>LF realization</u>:
	a. √123 ↔ /narís/	√123 ↔ λx. Nose(*x*)
	b. √12 ↔ /náso/	√12 ↔ λx. Nose(*x*)

Now, the syntactic representations of the antecedent and ellipsis site are radically different both in terms of representation and gender encoding. Since, by assumption, ellipsis obeys lexical-syntactic identity, the examples in (19) are ruled out as violations of identity in ellipsis. This is not the case under the MF approach in which conceptual meaning comes first, before *language*.

(27) el ___ de Juan y la ____ de Andrés

NOSE (concept)

Notice that in addition, given the architecture of the MF approach, one cannot explain the ungrammatical status of the relevant examples referring to the attested mismatch in gender. This is because gender in (19) cannot be part of the conceptual representation; it is a purely arbitrary property of the [*n*+√] complex. In sum, there is no obvious way to account for the ungrammatical examples in (19) within the MF approach. At least in this respect, a theory with roots indexes represented in the syntax seems to offer a better account of the attested ellipsis paradigms in Spanish or German.

In summary, the theory presented in the previous section explains at least this set of facts:

(28) a. the productivity of root doublets
b. the unproductivity of doublets for inflectional abstract morphemes
c. the arising of non-representational meanings in doublets (register, expressive, or social ones) as the byproduct of a sort of free variation at the syntax-PF interface

The observation in (28c) is captured by the PSM in (17), i.e., by the idea that exactly the same concept at LF can be represented through different root indexes in the syntax. So, in cases like this, free variation is just free index variation. The system, then, freely generates one index or another for the same concept but different PF meanings. Put differently, in the realm of lexical free variation, no blocking is observed.

3. Modeling the future alternations in Spanish

There is still the question whether the same can be said beyond lexical competition. Embick (2007) raises a similar point:

"Crucially, however, the use of *canine* in such a context does not mean that *dog* is not part of the grammar; it simply means that *dog* was not employed in that particular use of the grammar. The same considerations exist at a larger structural level as well. This is especially clear in the types of 'information-structure' or 'discourse-related' syntactic alternants. So, for example, the use of *Beans, I like* in some particular situation of use does not render *I like beans* ungrammatical. Each of these options is generated by the grammar, as distinct syntactic objects. The choice in this case is – as in the 'lexical' case – interpretable, in conjunction with other properties of the syntax of topicalization, of course."

[Embick 2007: 63]

Yet, he makes a crucial distinction between discourse-related phenomena and register-related phenomena. It could be that this is the right way to approach the problem, but I would like to explore another line of reasoning according to which at least some synthetic/analytic alternations in the register dimension are indeed generated by one single grammar at the PF interface, the locus of non-representational meanings of the type I am interested in in this study. Here is when our initial contrast in (29) becomes relevant:

(29) [*context*: the speaker is indicating a future event]

a. Estudiaré. [synthetic, specific formal situations]
study.FUT.1SG
'I will study.'

b. Voy a estudiar. [analytic, informal/everyday use]
go.PRES.1SG to study.INF
'I am going to study.'

As advanced, in Kroch (1994), related synthetic/analytic alternations in verbal systems are seen as underivable within one single grammatical system. On Kroch's view, the logic of syntactic change implies a sort of competition among structures which are incompatible in one single system. Then, in usage, incompatible alternations substitute for one another leading to grammatical systems with single outputs. Now, when concrete instances of doublets are attested, in particular, of the type illustrated in the synthetic/alternation in (29), the linguist must conclude that this type of variation implies competition between at least two grammatical systems. In Embick's (2007) words:

"The central tenet of the CG [competing grammar] approach is that certain types of variation are not contained within a single grammar. Rather, there are multiple grammars at play."

[Embick 2007: 65]

To this view, I would like to oppose the already advanced alternative solution. Briefly, the grammar of Rioplatense Spanish (and other Spanish varieties) generates the two representations in (29) at PF, not in the syntax. The resulting PF representations then are read for the context system which interprets the corresponding use-conditions. In the next subsection, I will offer some concrete implementation of this idea. And finally, I will address the problem of why the synthetic form does block the analytic form in the modal dimension, as illustrated in (2), repeated below:

(30) A. Dónde está Ana?
where is Ana
'Where is Ana?'
B. No sé. {Estará, #va a estar} en su casa.
not know.1sg be.FUT.3SG, goes to be.INF in her home
'I don't know. She might be at home.'

As I have already noted, the difference between the register and the modal instances of *estudiaré* is derived as standard case of structural ambiguity. In the following two subsections, I first introduce some important assumptions about clause structure and word formation in the Spanish verbal paradigm and then, I offer concrete analyses for the synthetic/analytical alternation both in the register and modal dimensions.

3.1. Some assumptions about clause structure and word formation

As is well-known, the Spanish verbal paradigm consists of the so-called *tiempos simples* and *compuestos* (simple and composed tenses). In the indicative mood, Spanish shows the following forms, excluding the future and conditional tenses, which are precisely the ones under study here:

(31) Synthetic or simple tenses (only first conjugation illustrated):
Presente: *trabajo* 'I work'
Pretérito perfecto simple: *canté* 'I worked'
Pretérito imperfecto: *cantaba* 'I used to work'

(32) Analytical or composed tenses:[4]
Pretérito perfecto compuesto: *he amado* 'I have worked'
Pretérito pluscuamperfecto: *había trabajado* 'I had worked'

I will assume a theory of the verbal paradigm in which the synthetic and the analytical forms are derived in the path from syntax to PF, along the lines suggested by the PF-movement approach already commented above:

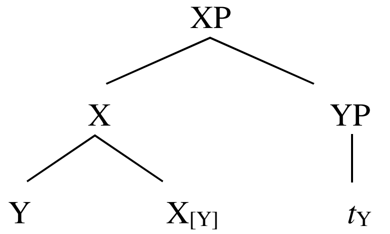
"*Syntax only:* Syntax performs operations that are explicitly executed so as to resolve a morphophonological problem. Patterns of apparent postsyntactic movement are reducible to the effects of these ''special'' syntactic processes.
PF movement: Syntax generates and moves terminals according to its own principles and is oblivious to morphophonological concerns. PF takes the output of syntax and resolves morphophonological dependencies according to its own principles."

[Embick and Noyer 2001: 556-557]

[4] I will not discuss the more complex composed tenses here, namely: (i) the perfect future (e.g., *habré trabajado* 'I will have worked') and (ii) the perfect conditional (e.g., habría trabajado 'I would have worked'). These cases also trigger the analytic/synthetic alternation the simple future and the simple conditional forms trigger but preserving the *haber*-insertion. Thus, *habré trabajado* alternates with *voy a haber trabajado* and *habría trabajado* with *iba a haber trabajado*. The analysis I proposed in Saab (2008) for these complex tenses plus the present approach predict the alternation.

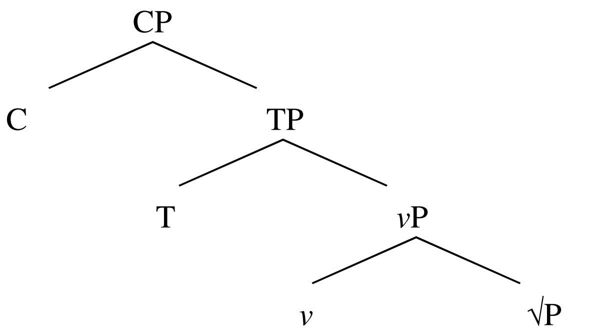
Among the relevant syntactic principles, I assume head movement as standardly defined in classic works by Travis (1984) and Baker (1988), i.e., as strictly cyclic head adjunction, an operation triggered by selectional features in the attracting head. Thus, in (33), the head X, with selectional feature [Y], attracts the head of its YP complement in the narrow syntax forming the complex head X, with Y and X as sub-heads:

(33)



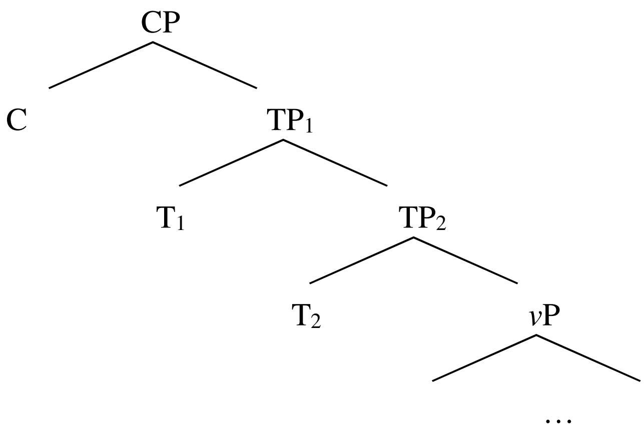
As is well-known, the nature of head movement has been under an intense dispute at least since Chomsky (2001), who relegated the operation to PF, mainly because of conceptual reasons. Since then, theories of head movement considerably increased. Without pretending to exhaust the families of theories, let me just mention three prominent views. Matushansky (2006) proposes to decompose head movement in a different set of syntactic and morphological operations. Gribanova and Harizanov (2019) argue that there are two different phenomena contained under the rubric of *head movement*: (i) syntactic head movement from head-to-specifier, and (ii) PF-amalgamation. Arregi and Pietraszko (2021) claim that, in reality, traditional syntactic head movement and traditional PF-lowering can be reduced to the same syntactic operation of *generalized head movement*. I cannot address the intricate arguments in favor of one approach or another; I will just restrict myself to assume the theory of Embick (2000) and Embick and Noyer (2001), both of which keep syntactic cyclic head movement via head-to-head adjunction adding the possibility of further PF-displacements or insertions, in consonance with the PF-movement approach already commented. Therefore, beyond syntactic head movement, further operations of auxiliary insertion and lowering/local dislocation apply at PF in the derivation of verbal forms, both of the synthetic or analytical types. Again, here too, there is an important debate regarding the nature of auxiliaries in verbal periphrases, with theories assuming pure syntactic approaches for periphrases (Harwood 2014), (hybrid) approaches assuming auxiliary insertion (at syntax or PF; see for instance, Embick 2000, Kornfeld 2004 and Saab 2008), or syntactic auxiliary merging via syntactic selection (Pietraszko 2023 and Arregi and Pietraszko 2025). I will assume that auxiliaries insert at PF without further motivation, but as we will see, it could be the case that after all the analytic/synthetic patterns in the register and modal dimensions require this approach for empirical reasons. To this already complex scenario, let me add a final caveat. Saab (2022a, to appear) has provided some empirical considerations to the effect of showing that at least in Romance traditional head movement only exists in a restricted subset of varieties (e.g., Portuguese or Galician), whereas in the other subset, head movement is illusory, the byproduct of the interaction between a set of PF-operations (restructuring, local dislocation, etc.). Unfortunately, I have to make important simplifications in this respect too. Yet, it is worth mentioning that the theory of register I am sketching here does not depend on the implementation I offer for analytical/synthetic tenses in the coming pages. With these provisos in mind, let me start with some basic assumptions regarding clause structure. Following works by Giorgi and Panesi (1997), Aranovich (2001), Kornfeld (2004) and Saab (2008), I will assume that in Spanish absolute and relative tenses have a different syntax. With some important simplifications, absolute tenses have the structure in (34):[5]

(34)



The T node encodes deictic temporal features, which can be modeled at LF in different ways (e.g., as intensional operators, as presuppositions, predicates, etc.). I will not be concerned with the proper LF representation of Spanish tenses (see Saab and Carranza 2021 for different theories of tense applied to Spanish). I just assume that the simplified structure in (34) underlies absolute tenses, e.g., the imperfect and perfect pasts (*trabajaba/trabajé* 'I worked$_{\text{imp/perf}}$') or the present (*trabajo* 'I work'). In relative tenses, an additional T node is present in the structure, T_2, which encodes relative tenses features such as [anterior] or [posterior]. Deictic tense, T_1, dominates T_2 in the syntax:

(35)



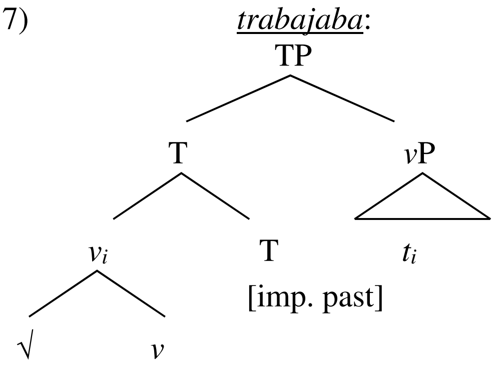
Now, with Saab (2008), inspired by similar ideas in Embick (2000), I contend that the verb moves until the first T head present in the structure, as stated below (Saab 2008: 216)

<u>Restriction on verbal head movement</u>:
(36) The verb (root+*v*) only moves until the first T head.

For simple tenses, this just gives us the standard V-to-T movement step, represented in (37) for the imperfect past of the verb *trabajar* 'to work':

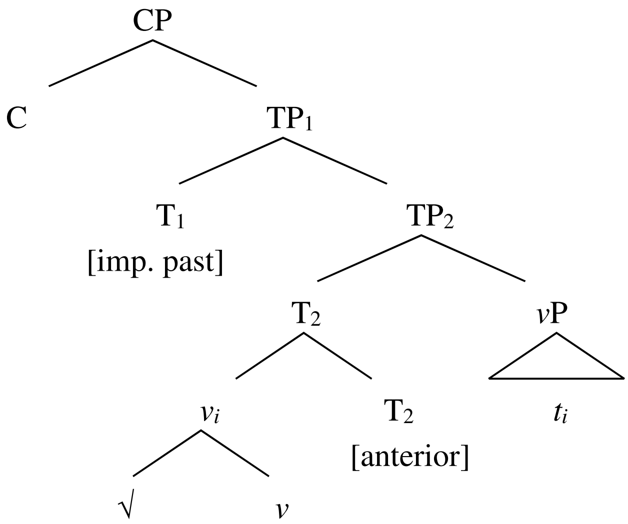
[5] I am omitting aspectual projections.

(37)



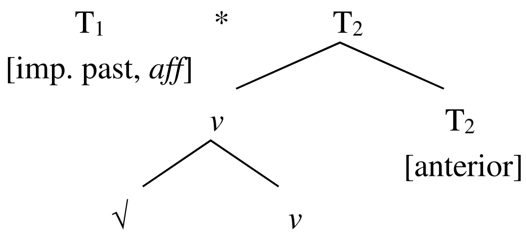
Now, for the case of, say, the *pluscuamperfecto había trabajado* 'I had worked', V-movement only reaches T_2 in compliance with the restriction in (36):

(38)



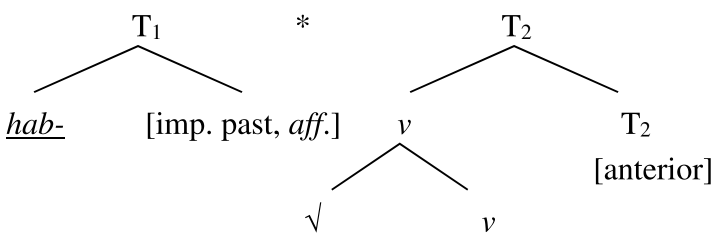
At PF, T_1 has an affixal nature and must be supported by a verbal base. *Haber*-insertion is the PF-mechanism that saves a possible stranded affix scenario (Lasnik 1981). The morphological description that feeds auxiliary insertion is represented in (39), where * stands for a linearization statement.

(39)



To this representation, the *haber* form is inserted to support the stranded affix:

(40)



After vocabulary insertion, the phonological information is added to the relevant terminal nodes (agreement nodes omitted):

(41) $[_{T1}$ hab-ía] * $[_{T2}$ [*v* cant+a]+$[_{T2}$ do]]

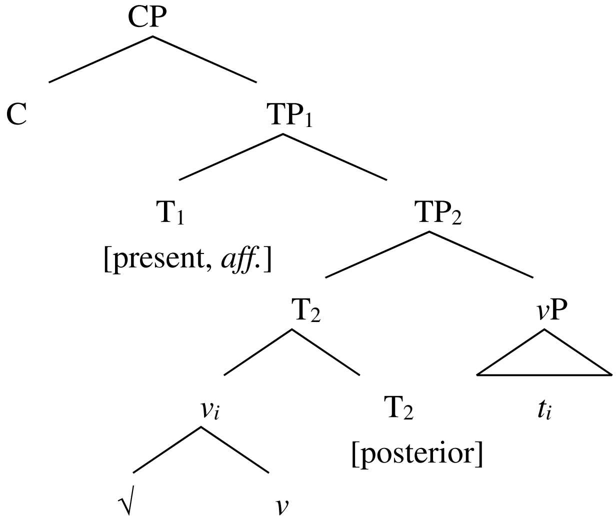
As shown in Kornfeld (2004), all the relative tenses of anteriority in Spanish have a similar derivation, only differentiated in the abstract features encoded in T_1 (present, imperfect past, etc.). Yet, this is not the case when T_2 encodes [posterior]. As already illustrated with the future or the conditional, the $T_{2[posterior]}$ node can either (i) be resolved through auxiliary insertion or (ii) through post-syntactic movement from T_1 to T_2. These two possibilities give rise to the synthetic / analytic alternation in all posterior tenses. For Kornfeld, yet, the synthetic / analytic distinction cannot survive within the same system, unless a difference in truth-conditional meaning is really at play. Therefore, synchronically Rioplatense Spanish only generates the analytic future and the synthetic modal. As in Kroch's approach, the synthetic future implies some sort of competition between two grammars. To this view, I offer the following alternative.

3.2. Deriving the synthetic/analytic alternation in the register dimension

I think that the sort of conceptions Kroch or Kornfeld favor with respect to the register alternations are not well-grounded. It seems more like an assumption regarding what linguistic meaning is really about. Put another way, why should we accept that the modal or the discourse dimensions (recall Embick's quotation above) are generated within one single system, but not the register dimension? This makes sense only if register is not about linguistic "meaning". However, this assumption does not look reasonable in multidimensional semantics (Potts 2005, Gutzmann 2015, Saab and Carranza 2021, among others), according to which there is no obvious sense in which "register" or, more properly, "use-conditions" are less meaningful than "truth-conditions". Of course, all these meanings convey different types of information and, as I have assumed, are interpreted by different cognitive systems (thought vs. context systems). I contend then that grammar outputs structures to the interfaces and that, depending on the locus of the relevant representations (simplifying, PF or LF), different types of meanings can be derived. Thus, in the same way that the grammaticality of *Beans, I like* does not make *I like beans* ungrammatical, the grammaticality of *voy a estudiar* 'I am going to study' does not make *estudiaré* 'I will study' ungrammatical or underivable in the register dimension within the same system. Therefore, the task is to provide the right syntactic and PF derivations and see whether PSM is operative or not. With Kornfeld, I assume that the synthetic and analytic futures have exactly the same syntax but, unlike her, I also propose to derive the two forms within the same dialect.[6] As for the syntax, she proposes an analysis similar to the [anterior] tenses with a difference in the specification of T_2, which in the future or the conditional encodes the feature [posterior], realized with the /-ɾ/ exponent at PF.

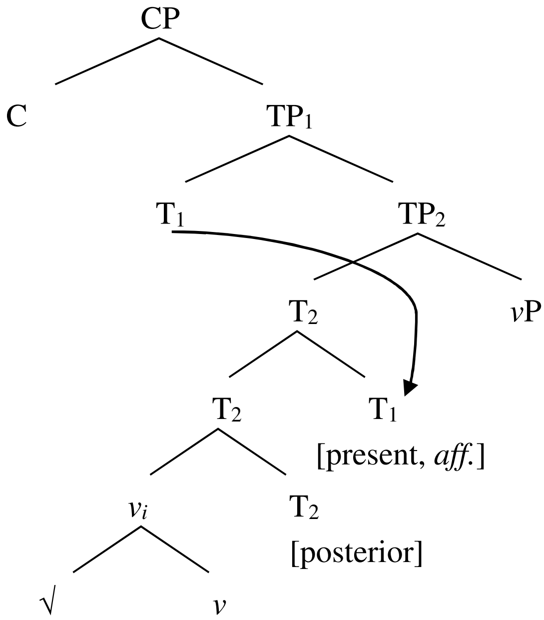
[6] I will omit discussion on the diachronic evolution of the alternations under study here. I think that the diachronic analysis already proposed in Kornfeld (2004) is a good alternative to other relevant works by Lema and Rivero (see, for instance, Lema 1994, Rivero 1994 and Lema and Rivero 1991).

(42) <u>Syntax for *voy a cantar/cantaré*</u>:



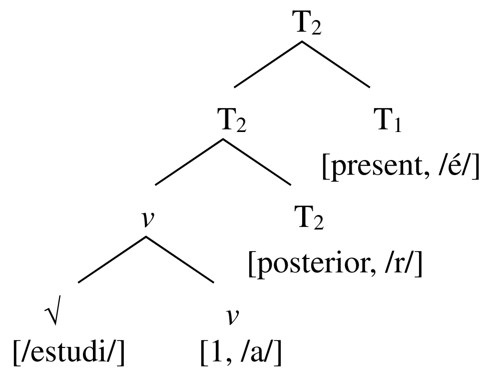
PF receives this result and resolves the stranded affix in T_1 in two ways, which results in the synthetic/analytical alternation. In the synthetic variant, as Kornfeld proposes, T_1 lowers to T_2 creating the following T_2 complex head:

(43)



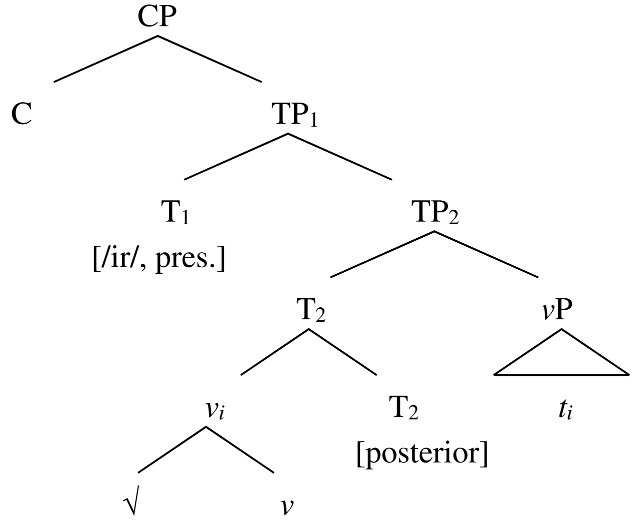
In the following tree, I show the vocabulary items corresponding to each terminal node. Again, there are various omissions and simplifications, but irrelevant to the point I am making here:

(44) <u>*estudi-a-r-é:*</u>



Alternatively, there is no lowering and the *ir* auxiliary is inserted in the context of a $T_{[posterior]}$ environment.

(45) <u>*voy a estudiar:*</u>



Ir-insertion supports the stranded T_1 affix and lowering does not apply. This is a rough sketch of a plausible derivation. There are many remaining details that should be integrated into a most sophisticated analysis. For instance, on this analysis, there is still need for a rule of preposition insertion, which adds the preposition *a* ‘to’ as a dissociated node for T_2 (in the sense of Embick and Noyer 2001). Explicit assumptions regarding the mechanics underlying the synthetic/analytical alternation should inform us how exactly the entire final representation is obtained. For instance, it still could be the case that the insertion of the preposition in the [posterior] environment blocks lowering from T_1 to T_2, feeding then *ir*-insertion and ultimately giving rise to the analytical variant. This would be a plausible motivation for the trigger of the relevant rules. I will not take any particular stance with respect to these important issues. I will instead focus on the other side of the relevant derivations, the LF-side. With important simplifications, let us just assume a simple intensional approach to the future roughly along the following lines

(46) LF for *estudiaré/voy a estudiar*: $[\![\text{FUT}(p)]\!]^t = \lambda p_{<i,t>}.\ \exists t'$ posterior to t: $p(t') = 1$.

If the two structures survive in a single system, a more general version of PSM must then apply. Let me state the more general version of the PSM as follows:

(47) Principle of stylistic meaning (PSM): Given a pair of abstract objects X and Y, generated by the grammatical system, if X and Y are not semantically distinguishable at LF, they are "semantically" distinguished at PF.

[Saab 2021a: 23]

A reasonable PF bias for the synthetic future would restrict its use to some particular situations:

(48) PF-*bias:* $c \in CU$(*synthetic future*) only if, in c, c_a is a participant in register *formal*

This is probably not the better statement, but enough for my present purposes. A more elaborated version of the theory should consider other uses of the synthetic. For instance, in Rioplatense Spanish the synthetic form is also used in ludic environments by children. Therefore, the term *formal* in (48) would require important qualifications or more PF-biases must be listed for the synthetic. I leave all these important details for future research.

For now, let me stress one of the particularities of this account, namely: the fact that it preserves many of the findings in past research on variation in language use. In effect, the proposed analysis does not introduce variation or free variation in exponence at the level of abstract morphemes. As observed in the previous section, doublets are extremely rare at this level, a fact that straightforwardly follows from the architecture of the grammar assumed, according to which variation in functional exponence is prevented by competition for the same node. On my analysis, this situation does not obtain in the future or conditional alternations, since that "optionality" is not encoded in vocabulary insertion but in the application of the relevant PF rules: lowering vs. auxiliary insertion. The structure obtained by the application of one rule blocks the application of the other rule and each of the final structures introduces different conditions for insertion. Therefore, there is no free variation but standard morphological competition, i.e., allomorphy.

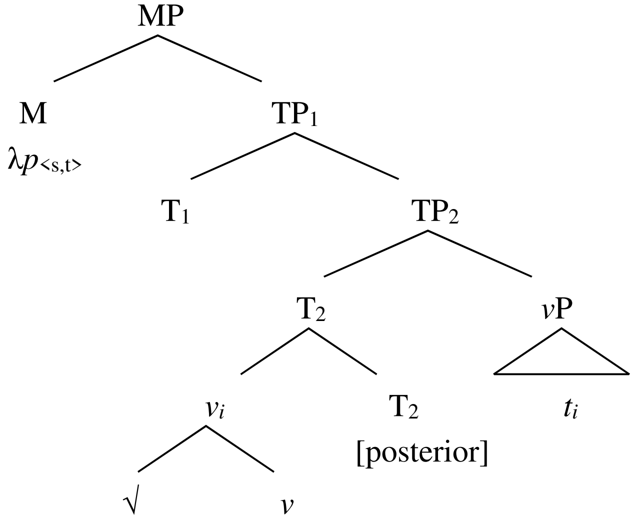
3.3. Deriving the synthetic/analytic alternation in the modal dimension

Consider now the modal use of the synthetic future:

(49) A. Dónde está Ana?
where is Ana
'Where is Ana?'
B. No sé. {Estará, #va a estar} en su casa.
not know.1sg be.FUT.3SG, goes to be.INF in her home
'I don't know. She might be at home.'

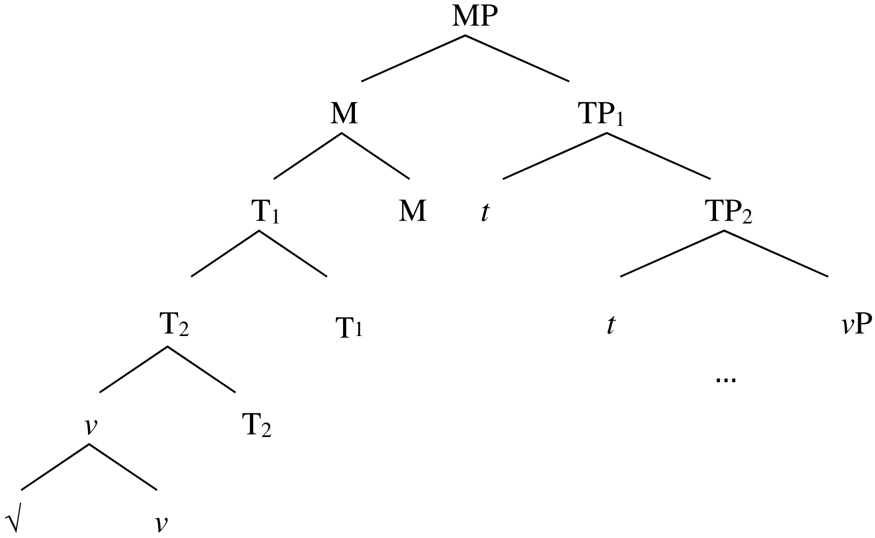
Unlike what is observed with respect to the register dimension, in this case grammar generates one meaning, which can only be expressed by the synthetic form not the analytical one. Since the modal meaning is truth-conditionally relevant, there are good reasons to introduce a different syntax. Partially following Kornfeld's (2004) analysis, the modal reading arises because there is a dominating modal head above T_1.

(50) *estudiaré:*



Moreover, I propose that this additional functional node is endowed with a selectional verbal feature triggering syntactic head movement. Then, in order to reach M, the verb must move cyclically from its base position to the M position, crucially creating in its way a previous head adjunction structure at the T_1 node.

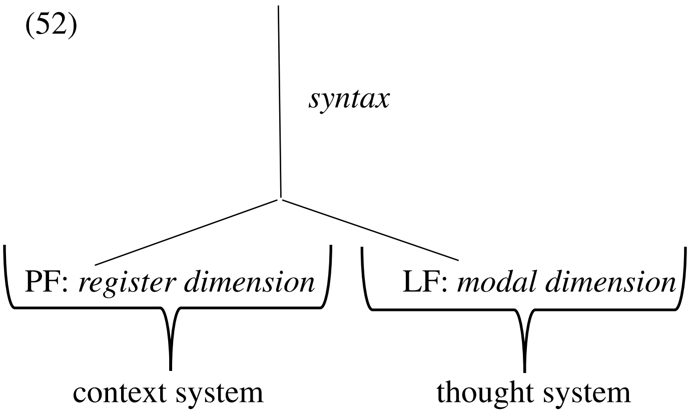
(51) *estudiaré:*



At PF, the analytical form is underivable since syntactic head movement has already created the environment that supports the stranded affix at the T_1 position. Given the contrast in the modal dimension, in which the analytical form cannot have the required meaning, this is a welcome result. Notice an important aspect of this analysis: if on the right track, then we would have added a novel argument in favor of the post-syntactic nature of auxiliary insertion. The reason is that if auxiliaries are directly generated in the syntax on T_1 (or in a node local to it below M), then the introduction of the M node will trigger head movement of the auxiliary incorrectly giving rise to an analytic future with modal meaning. In other words, both the synthetic and the analytical forms would be derivable in the modal dimension, contrary to fact.

In summary, I have implemented an analysis for the analytical/synthetic alternation both in the register and modal dimensions. The analysis is based on the thesis that both synthetic forms are generated within a single grammar as a standard case of structural ambiguity. However, unlike other forms of structural ambiguity, the two synthetic forms are associated with qualitatively different meanings: use- vs. truth-conditional meanings. This is not fortuitous; it follows from architectural considerations according to which, depending on the timing and locus of grammatical rules, different interpretative systems, context or thought systems, are activated. On this view, the register dimension is the result of a PF representation created in the path from syntax to PF, whereas the modal dimension is the result of an LF representation, the output of a syntax-LF derivation. This is schematically illustrated with the diagram in (7), adapted below:

(52)



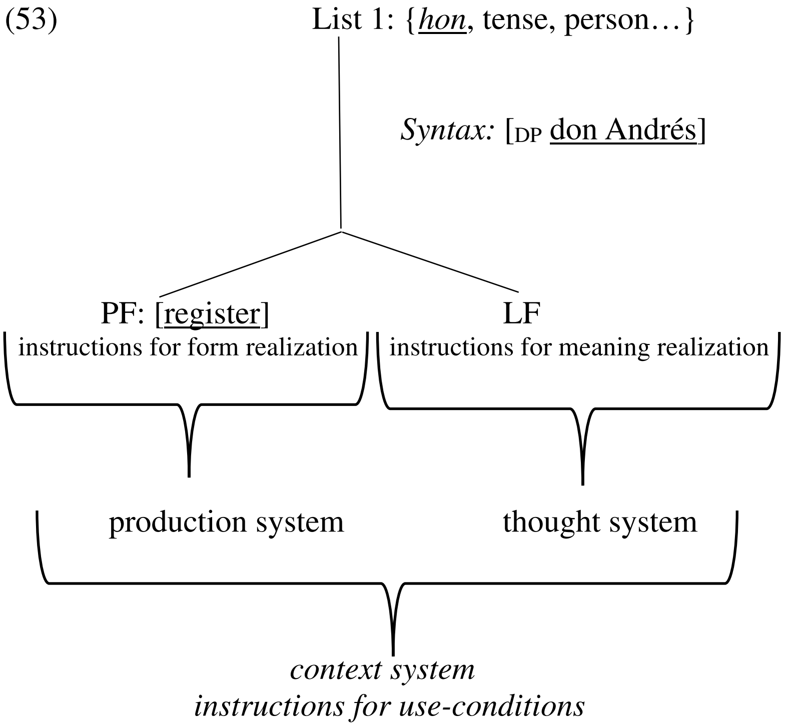
4. Further discussion and extensions

In this section, I first offer some further comments on the model of non-representational meanings sketched in the previous section. Then, I briefly discuss another pattern of free variation in PF-rules: the optionality of the definite article with referential uses of proper name in some Spanish varieties. The considerations I introduce with respect to this pattern add another plausible good case for non-representational grammar, in the sense favored in this study. The section concludes discussing some important methodological issues, illustrated with reference to accusative clitic doubling in Rioplatense Spanish.

4.1. On the locus of non-representational meanings

The picture offered so far is still partial. There are plausible reasons to think that the context system can access both the PF and the LF interface in a more global way. Recently, this was independently argued by Ruda (2019) and Saab (2023) on the basis of different empirical considerations. For instance, some form of honorification entirely depends on lexical encoding in List 1. A clear case is the use of the honorific *don/doña* 'HON.M / HON.F' in Spanish (e.g., *Don Andrés*, *Doña Andrea*), a pure expressive in Potts (2005) terms, which can roughly be characterized as introducing respect for the referent of the proper name on the speaker's part. In Saab (2021b), I have defended that idea that *don/doña* can indeed be modeled as a Potts' expressive. If this is correct, it means that honorification by *don/doña*, a kind of non-representational meaning, is derived through lexical encoding in List 1 plus whatever axiom delivers the expressive meaning. Therefore, *don* combines with, say, the proper name *Andrés* in the syntax and triggers an expressive axiom at LF which delivers the proper use-conditions. On this view, it has to be the case that some non-representational meanings (register, for instance) must be interpreted from a PF output, but others, from an LF output. This results in the following picture:

(53)



There could be other ways of addressing this form of honorification. For instance, at the truth-conditional dimension the honorific *don/doña* is innocuous (perhaps, interpreted as a mere identity function) but it contributes to the honorification system in an additional dimension of meaning. If such a meaning can be modeled in the sense favored in this study, then we could have the following bias:

(54) *bias:* $c \in CU$([HON + proper name]) only if, in c, c_a honors the referent of the PN

If what the context system reads is the resulting LF structure, then the architecture in (53) looks more accurate than the pure PF architecture for the context system. In the concluding section, based on recent findings by Lo Guercio (2025), I give some further reason to think that the honorific *don/doña* must indeed be interpreted from an LF output by the context system, favoring the architecture in (53). Yet, one way or another, the honorific seems to be indubitable part of List 1 and combined in narrow syntax. This fact makes it implausible to think of a single locus for non-representational meanings in grammar and opens the analytic space in complex ways. A priori, there is no way to know whether a certain putative instance of syntactic variation is resolved in the path from narrow syntax to PF, in the path from narrow syntax to LF or other plausible complex interactions between syntax, the interfaces and the external cognitive systems. To illustrate this complexity, I discuss a final case study arguing that even superficial similar semantic phenomena (honorification vs. interpersonal proximity) must have underlyingly different derivations in the syntax and the interfaces.

4.2. Determined proper names in Rioplatense Spanish

For some Spanish speakers, proper names can be realized in two ways, namely, in their canonical bare form or modified for an expletive article:

(55)	(la)	Ana,	(el)	Andrés
	the.F.SG	Ana	the.M.SG	Andrés

For those Rioplatense speakers in which the choice exists, such a choice is not use-conditionally innocuous. The determined use of the proper name is restricted to informal situations in which the speaker is in a relation of *interpersonal proximity* with respect to the referent of the proper name (Oggiani and Aguilar-Guevara 2024). How is this meaning derived within the grammatical system? As noticed in Saab (2021b, 2025), a priori, this use of the article seems to form a natural class with the honorific *don/doña* briefly discussed above. For instance, both terms behave the same with respect to expressivity diagnostics. I will only mention two prominent ones: (i) *independence* from truth-conditional operators and (ii) *speaker-orientation* (see Potts 2005 for more diagnostics). As for independence, both *don/doña* and the expressive article remain unaffected in the scope of truth-conditional operators. Consider negation in (56):

(56) No vi a *doña/la* Ana.
not saw.1SG ACC HON/DET Ana
a. Truth-conditional meaning: I didn't see Ana
b. Non-representational meaning: The speaker respects/is close to Ana.

Negation here affects the truth-conditional proposition that the speaker saw Ana, but not the honorific or interpersonal proximity meanings introduced by *doña* and *la*, respectively. Furthermore, both items are strongly speaker-oriented. So even in (57), in which the subject of the attitude predicate could be a potential candidate for being the bearer of respect/interpersonal proximity, the relevant expressive attitudes can only be attributed to the speaker:

(57) Ana cree que *doña/la* Paula es inteligente.
Ana believes that HON/DET Paula is intelligent
a. Truth-conditional meaning: Ana believes that Paula is smart.
b. Non-representational meaning: The speaker respects/is close to Paula.

Given these similarities one could be tempted to capture the behavior of the expressive article in the same way as the honorific *don/doña*, i.e., as an expressive operator triggering a particular expressive axiom. Yet, in Saab (2025), I challenge this uniform analysis. On the one hand, the historical development of the honorific justifies the assignment of an intrinsic honorific meaning to it, but this is not the case with respect to the expressive article. More importantly, whereas the article is associated with the D head (in ways to make more precise), the honorific is associated with a lower position in the DP structure. One clear piece of evidence for this distribution is vocatives, which only make honorifics licit, not expressive articles:

(58) a. Doña Ana, venga.
HON Ana come.SUBJ
'HON Ana, come.'
b. * La Ana, vení.
DET Ana come.IMP

This follows from the standard assumption that vocatives are incompatible with articles in general (see Resnik 2014, to appear for Spanish). However, unlike regular definite articles, the expressive determiner is insensitive to the morphophonology of the adjacent noun. As is well-known, (in)definite articles *la* or *una* changes to *el* or *un* whenever followed by nouns beginning with stressed *a*. Saab and Lo Guercio (2020) argue that the following allomorphy rules account, then, for the patterns in (60):

(59) a. D[feminine, singular, definite] ↔ /el/ / ___ * [$_n$ √/á…/]
/la/, elsewhere
b. D[feminine, singular, indefinite] ↔ /un/ / ___ * [$_n$ √/á…/]
/una/, elsewhere

(60) a. el {hacha, el águila, el aula, el arma, …}
the.F.SG {ax, eagle, classroom, weapon, … }[7]
b. un {hacha, águila, aula, arma… }
a.F.SG {ax, eagle, classroom, weapon, … }

The rule does not apply whenever the article is followed by a proper name, both in predicate uses of proper names (61a) or in expressive uses (61b), as the ones I am interested in here:

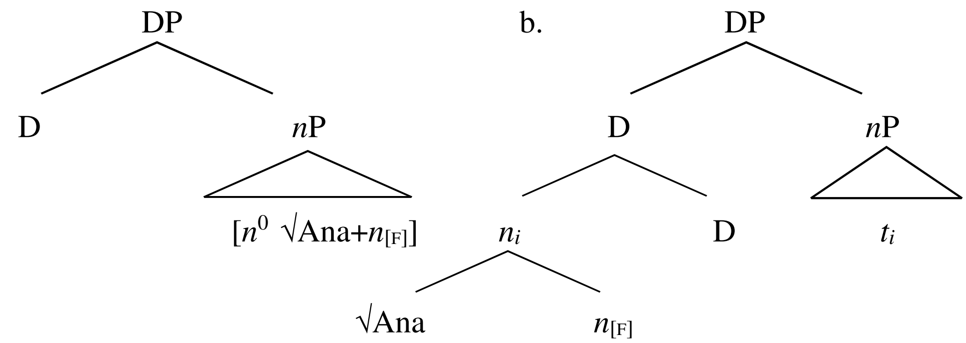
(61) a. *El/la Ana que conozco… *predicate use*
the.FEM.SG A. that know.1SG
'The Ana I know…'
b. Voy a la casa de *el/la Ana. *expressive use*
go.1SG to the houseof the.FEM.SG A.
'I went to Ana's house.'

The blocking of the allomorphic rule cannot be due to the female semantic nature of the relevant proper names. Common nouns with also female referents do trigger the rule:

(62) a. el ama de llaves, un ama de llaves
the.F.SG housekeeper.F.SG a.F.SG housekeeper.FEM
b. el hada madrina, un hada madrina
the.F.SG Fairy Godmother.FEM.SG a..F.SG Fairy Godmother.FEM

So, the reason the rule does not apply in (61) must be structural. For the case of predicative uses like (61a), Saab and Lo Guercio provide arguments to the effect of showing that the syntax of predicative uses bleeds the adjacency condition in (59). They do not discuss the expressive uses in any detail, but in Saab (2025) I have argued that the structure of DPs with expressive determiners also bleeds the adjacency condition according to which the article and the noun must be adjacent. To see the idea, let me start assuming with Longobardi (1994, 2005) that proper names move from their nominal position to the D head via syntactic head movement. Thus, for a proper name like *Ana*, its syntax would have at least the following ingredients:[8]

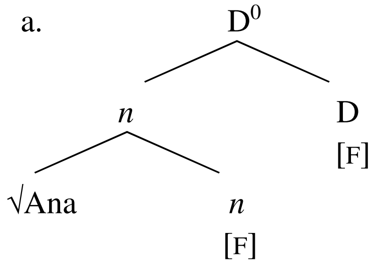
(63) a. b.



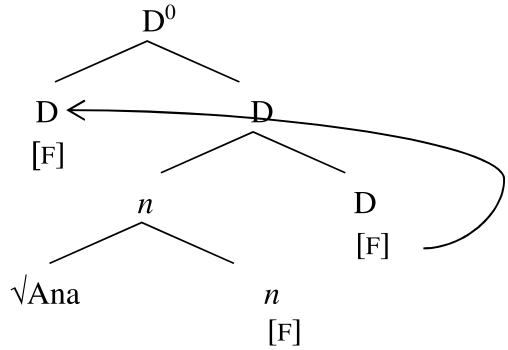
[7] I translate the article *el* (or *un*) that modifies these feminine nouns just as feminine singular, and not as masculine singular (like the true masculine article, *el*). Diachronically, the feminine *el* derived from Latin *illa*, not *ille*, unlike the masculine article.
[8] Although see Saab (in press) for a PF alternative.

PF receives the complex head in (64a) and then, the gender features on *n* are copied into D by an application of Concord. Now, I argue that for those varieties in which there is the choice of adding an expressive definite article there is an additional operation of insertion of a dissociated morpheme (Embick and Noyer 2001), as illustrated in (64b):

(64) a.



b.



Alternatively, we can just extend the strategy I used for the synthetic/analytical alternation and assume that the article occurs whenever head movement does not apply in the syntax. Under this scenario, the article is inserted to support a possible stranded affix filter scenario. If I prefer not following this at first sight more parsimonious analysis is because it cannot explain why in (61b) we have *La Ana* and not **El Ana*. In effect, under the article insertion strategy, the structure in (65) would obtain, consequently, triggering the rule in (59a):

(65) $[_{\mathrm{D}^0}\ \mathrm{D}_{[\text{feminine, singular, definite}]}]\ *\ [_{n}\ \surd/\text{á}\ldots/\ ]$

Instead, under the analysis in (64b), the higher D would never occur adjacent to the name /ána/, but to the cyclic head D (Embick 2010).

(66) $[_{\mathrm{D}^0}\ \mathrm{D}_{[\text{feminine, singular, definite}]}]\ *\ [_{\mathrm{D}}\ \ldots\ ]$

At any rate, both analyses result in exactly the type of free variation situation discussed in section 3 regarding the synthetic/analytic alternation in the future/conditional. And as we have already seen, this activates the PSM, repeated below from (47):

(67) Principle of stylistic meaning (PSM): Given a pair of abstract objects X and Y, generated by the grammatical system, if X and Y are not semantically distinguishable at LF, they are "semantically" distinguished at PF.

[Saab 2021a: 23]

A plausible PF-bias for the relevant construction would be as follows:

(68) PF-*bias:* $c \in CU$(ART + proper name) only if, in c, c_a is a participant in an informal register and is in interpersonal proximity with the referent of the PN

A crucial aspect of this analysis is that it assumes that ⟦Ana⟧ = ⟦la Ana⟧. For instance, what must be shown is that the descriptive semantic of *la Ana* is the same descriptive semantic of a referential proper name and not, say, the descriptive semantic of a predicative proper name. Predicative uses of proper names are indeed attested in all dialect of Spanish and, as shown in detail in Saab and Lo Guercio (2020), have a different syntax, semantics and pragmatics than referential uses of proper names. One crucial difference is that referential uses of proper names do not admit pluralization, a perfect output in predicative uses:

(69) a. * Anas vinieron.[9]
Anas came.3PL
b. Las Anas que conozco vinieron.
the.PL Anas that know.1SG came.3PL
'The Anas I know came.'

Note now that the following sentence is perfectly grammatical in all dialects under the predicative reading:

(70) Las Anas vinieron.
the.PL Anas came.3PL
'The Anas came.'

Interestingly, for the speakers who admit the expressive article with proper names, the sentence in (70) loses the interpersonal proximity reading attested in the singular counterpart. This shows that the syntax/semantics of predicative uses of proper names must be radically different from the syntax/semantics of referential uses with and without article. Furthermore, this (plus other plausible reasons) leads to the conclusion that the referential uses with and without article also share the same underlying syntax and, perhaps, descriptive semantics.

In sum, the observed intraspeaker variation in the use of the definite article with proper names in Rioplatense Spanish and other varieties follows as a case of D doubling by dissociation at PF. The distribution and interpretation of the alternation meet all the criteria for detecting use-conditions of the relevant type after PF. Importantly, it is not dissociation the trigger of the relevant use-conditional meaning but the alternation between structures with and without article. In the general case, when dissociation is forced and does not freely alternate with non-dissociated structures there is no trace of use-conditions. This is the case, for instance, in all those cases in which person and number dissociation is forced in subject-verb agreement patterns in a myriad of languages of the world. But more importantly, it seems to be also the case in Chilean Spanish in which the use of the article with proper names is perhaps becoming obligatory (see Muñoz Pérez 2024 for recent discussion on Chilean Spanish).

The considerations just made have important methodological implications. It seems to me that the approach I am suggesting gives us a good heuristic to proceed in the realm of syntactic (free) variation. Given an attested pattern of intraspeaker syntactic variation, we should be able to detect the activity of PSM. If what I have said is at least partially correct, and such activity can indeed be detected, then one would have good reasons to suspect that the locus of variation is entirely resolved at PF through the optional application of certain morphological rules. If, on the contrary, one cannot detect the type of non-representational meanings that characterize different kinds of expressive and register constructions, there are then good reasons to look for different syntactic-semantic derivations. There are many gray zones in the languages of the world. In some cases, only in-depth grammatical experimentation can resolve what type of semantic output is being delivered for a given derivation. As a brief illustration, consider a very-well know alternation in Rioplatense Spanish, accusative clitic doubling:

[9] Notice that the sentence is grammatical if the subject is postnominal (e.g., *Vinieron Anas*.). This makes sense if in the postnominal position there is an occurrence of a predicative proper name, not of a referential one, since bare NPs in subject position are only allowed in postnominal position.

(71) Ana (la) vio a Paula.
Ana (CL.F.ACC.3SG) saw ACC Paula
'Ana saw Paula.'

At first approximation, variation in clitic doubling does not obviously impact on (i) register, (ii) truth-conditions, or (iii) information-structure. When asked for the choices in (71), the normal reaction speakers use to have is a robust "I don't know". Of course, corpus studies[10] can detect important differences in, say, frequency, but I am convinced that this is not the type of phenomena to be accounted for within the theory of non-representational grammar, whose aim is explaining an aspect of linguistic competence. Put differently, the type of expressivity/register effects under consideration here involve linguistic behaviors determined by principles of the language faculty. Typical frequency or persistence effects (just to mention two) are performance effects due to extra-linguistic factors. Then, all things being equal, something must be wrong with the rough characterization of clitic doubling in at least one of the three domains listed above. In fact, as shown in recent work by Di Tullio *et al* (2019) and, in particular, in Saab (2022b, 2024), accusative clitic doubling is not inert in the syntax or at LF, casting serious doubts on point (ii) above. Elaborating on an original observation by Hurtado (1984), these works show that accusative clitic doubling can repair Weak Crossover effects. Consider the example in (72), in which focus fronting of a referential direct object crossing a possessive pronoun in subject position makes the indicated co-reference very hard to get:

(72) *? A ANA$_i$ criticó su$_i$ madre.
ACC Ana criticized her mother
Intended: 'Her mother criticized ANA.'

The sentence becomes perfect whenever clitic doubling applies:

(73) A ANA$_i$ <u>*la*</u> criticó su$_i$ madre.
ACC Ana CL.ACC.F.3SG criticized her mother
'Her mother criticized ANA.'

This contrast can be explained if the structures with and without doubling have different syntactic and LF structures. I cannot review the argument here, so I just refer to the relevant works already cited for in-depth discussion and more references.

5. Conclusions

I have described how a theory for the synthetic/analytical alternation in the register and modal dimensions should look like under the assumption that both dimensions are generated by the same grammar. The core idea is that certain types of use-conditional meanings are obtained because of certain specific morphological activity at PF. I have called this activity *grammatical free variation*, not because the members of a given alternation cannot be motivated by internal morphological requirements, but because of their mere existence, i.e., the fact that they can indeed be generated within one single grammar, is truth-conditionally/descriptively innocuous at LF and beyond (i.e., for the thought system). Free variation at PF is not, however, use-conditional innocuous; it triggers different flavors of non-representational meanings from register to pure expressivity interpreted by the context system. A different scenario is attested in the modal dimension in which there is no true alternation, and one form is truth-conditionally

[10] Important recent corpus studies both from diachronic/synchronic and comparative points of view are found in Rinke *et al* (2019) and Rinke *et al* (2023).

different from another. I have provided a preliminary analysis that would account both for the fact the analytical form is "blocked" by the synthetic one and for its LF impact.

The register and modal interpretations are obtained in different meaning dimensions, but no one is "more" semantic than the other one. If formal theories of grammar expulsed free variation and register meanings from the domain of core grammar is just because of a certain dogma according to which register is not exactly linguistic meaning. This is precisely the main point of disagreement I have tried to make explicit in this contribution. This does not imply denying the different nature of each type of meaning; on the contrary, if the theory of non-representational grammar is at least partially correct, we can make sense of why those meanings have the nature they have. For instance, while in both cases there is certain notion of competition among choices or alternatives involved, only those meanings generated at the syntax-LF interface form true Horn-alternatives of the well-known type in the theory of scalar implicatures (Horn 1972). A great deal of theorizing in this domain in the last two decades has focused on the very nature of scalar alternatives. One important conclusion is that there are good reasons to derive scalar meanings directly from the syntax-LF path. It turned out that the activity of a cover LF operator can be detected in the relevant empirical domains, the so-called *exh(austification)* (see Chierchia 2004, Fox 2007 and much subsequent work since then). The absence of such kinds of cover operators in the register dimension is straightforwardly derived from the architecture of non-representational grammar offered here. Put differently, I conjecture that if there is a clear-cut distinction between choices (register) and alternatives (scalar implicatures) is because of the locus of each meaning dimension.
Again, it is not always clear whether we are dealing with PF choices or LF alternatives. For instance, Lo Guercio (2025) shows that register doublets coming from different lexical roots as the ones discussed in section 2 do not produce scalar reasoning. Thus, the use of the informal *birra* 'beer' "does not license the kind of alternative-based scalar reasoning" (Lo Guercio 2015: 19), as shown in the following example:

(74)	a.	Quiero	comprar	una	cerveza.
		want.1SG	buy.INF	a	beer
		'I want to buy a beer.'			
		$\nrightarrow$ ¬(the context is informal)			
	a.	Quiero	comprar	una	birra.
		want.1SG	buy.INF	a	beer.INFORMAL
		'I want to buy a beer$_{\text{INFORMAL}}$.'			

[Lo Guercio 2025: 19]

This is what the present approach predicts, under the reasonable assumption the *Exh* is a cover LF operator, not a PF one. Now, interestingly, the relevant scalar inference is triggered by the honorific *don/doña*:

(75)	Primer	entró	Donato.	Después	entró	Don	Pedro.
	first	entered	Donato	afterwards	entered	HON.M	Pedro
	→ ¬(the speaker honors Donato)						

[adapted from Lo Guercio 2025: 13]

Recall from the previous discussion that we were not certain regarding the exact derivational path for this type of honorific. What we do know is that List 1 provides syntax with an abstract morpheme [HON], but then I conjectured that in principle there are two competing analyses for deriving the relevant use-conditions: either at LF, if the context system also has access to this interface, or directly at PF, as in the *cerveza/beer* case. Lo Guercio's findings seem to favor a syntax-LF approach for the honorific *don/doña*, since for this case scalar inferences of the usual type can be detected once discourses are properly manipulated. If this is correct, then presence or absence of scalar meanings can be added to the toolkit for detecting the locus of a given meaning dimension.

I would like to end with a final question for which I have no conclusive answer yet: is there any clear-cut division between the competing grammar approach and the single grammar one? Of course, there are many digressions to make with respect to this point, which will take us further than is reasonable. Yet, there is an interesting connection between solutions involving multilingual activity and multi-PF derivations (i.e., derivations that manipulate the same syntactic output to deliver free variation effects). In both cases, what remains the same is the path from syntax to thought. In other words, it could just be the case that multilingualism is an extreme instance of the multi-PF derivation strategy.

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